

ARABESQUE ▼ A decorative style based on sinuous lines, often incorporating plant motifs. Arabesques are typically derived from Islamic art, hence the name.



ARCADE A covered passage with arches along one or both sides. In modern use, an arcade can also be a covered passageway of shops.

ARCH See panel, below.

ARCHITRAVE A beam that rests on the capitals of columns. In modern buildings, the architrave is the wooden molding that frames a door or window. *See also* capital, column, entablature.

ART DECO A decorative art style of the 1920s and 1930s. Taking its name from the International Exhibition of Modern Decorative

and Industrial Arts, held in Paris in 1925, the style was characterized by bold, geometric lines and shapes; strong symmetry; and a modern, streamlined look.

ART NOUVEAU A decorative art style popular from approximately 1890 until World War I. Whimsical in nature, Art Nouveau employed undulating, asymmetrical shapes and lines, typically evoking the forms of flowers, plants, insects, and other natural objects.

ASHLAR Stone that has been cut and smoothed into regular-shaped blocks and laid in a bricklike fashion.

ATRIUM An open space in a building that extends up through several floors, often with a glass roof. Atriums are a common feature of hotels and shopping centers.

AUDITORIUM A place where people gather to watch a performance. In architectural terms, this is the part of a theater or concert hall where the audience sits, or a building used for events such as concerts.

AVANT GARDE Pioneering or experimental.

AVENUE A wide road with trees or tall buildings on either side.

AXIAL PLANE An arrangement of elements along an extended central axis.

AXIS A real or imaginary straight line to which elements on a plan relate, typically through symmetry.

AZULEJO A type of Spanish and Portuguese tiling. Colorful, glazed azulejo tiles are commonly used as decorative elements on the interiors and exteriors of churches, palaces, and public buildings.

B

BAILEY A courtyard in a castle or fortress enclosed by a wall. Larger structures might often have an outer (lower) bailey and an inner (upper) bailey. *See also* castle.

BALCONY A platform projecting from the outside wall of a building, with a low wall and railings or a balustrade for safety. *See also* balustrade.

ARCH

An arch is a structure that is curved at the top and directs load around an opening, transferring it to pillars, piers, abutments, or walls on either side. Its construction depends on wedge-shaped blocks, called voussoirs, in which the upper part of the block is wider than the lower part. The central voussoir is called the keystone. During construction, the voussoirs require support from below until the keystone has been put in place to lock the arch.

The completed structure is self-supporting, held in compression by gravity and the weight of the structure above. This makes arches stable and efficient and capable of spanning larger distances and supporting greater loads than a horizontal beam. Different types of arches have evolved over time, while the techniques of arch-building have developed into many other structural forms, such as vaults and domes.

